

This recording is a discovery-style meeting between Speaker 1 and Farouk, focused on understanding the current operational problems inside Farouk's property management business and identifying what kind of website, system, or automation platform would help streamline the company.

The business appears to manage approximately 100 tenants. Farouk is currently heavily involved in day-to-day operations, including tenant communication, payment tracking, maintenance coordination, leasing decisions, accounting oversight, budgeting, and vendor or contractor coordination. The main theme of the conversation is that the company has grown to a point where its current informal systems are creating bottlenecks, manual work, missed opportunities, and an overdependence on Farouk.

The website or platform that needs to be built should not simply be a marketing website. It should function as an operational hub that helps centralize leasing, tenant communication, payments, maintenance requests, document access, task routing, reporting, and internal decision workflows.

Current Systems and Tools Mentioned

1. Innago

Farouk's team uses Innago as a tenant-facing platform.

It currently handles:

- Tenant payments
- Tenant ledgers
- Maintenance requests
- Tenant communication
- Some admin documents

However, Innago is not fully adopted by tenants. Farouk estimates that:

- Around 60% of tenants may use Innago for payments.
- Around 40% to 50% of tenants may use it when contacting the company or submitting maintenance requests.

This creates a problem because the business technically has a system, but tenant behavior is fragmented. Many tenants still contact Farouk directly or use alternative payment methods.

Farouk is frustrated because Innago:

- Does not provide sufficient background accounting functionality.
- Does not sync well with their leasing needs.
- Is no longer being used for advertising.
- Has not become the central place where all tenants reliably interact with the business.
- Creates extra manual work when tenants bypass the platform.

2. Zillow Rental

The company uses Zillow Rental for leasing and listing rental properties.

This appears to be one of the primary channels for generating tenant leads. However, the leasing process is not centralized, and Zillow is only one part of the funnel.

3. Facebook

The company also uses Facebook for rental listings and lead generation.

Like Zillow, Facebook is being used because the business does not currently have its own dedicated listings page or leasing funnel.

4. Short Landlord / Accounting Service

Farouk recently signed a short-term contract with a company referred to as Short Landlord, connected to a person named John.

This company is being used for accounting support. The plan is for them to:

- Link bank accounts.
- Link credit cards.
- Review transactions.
- Match transactions.
- Ask the team questions when clarification is needed.
- Produce accounting reports.

Farouk wants more frequent and actionable accounting visibility. His ideal would be a near-live or frequently updated profit-and-loss view, updated every one to two weeks, broken down by property.

Major Pain Points Identified

1. Leasing Is Not Streamlined

Farouk identifies leasing as likely the biggest area of opportunity cost.

The company is able to lease properties, and Farouk believes the properties are usually presented well. However, he questions whether they are leasing fast enough and whether they are attracting the highest-quality tenants possible.

The current leasing process relies on external platforms like Zillow Rental and Facebook. The company does not have its own page where listings can be added, presented, and managed directly.

The leasing process lacks:

- A centralized listings page
- A unified application funnel
- Automated lead collection
- Lead scoring or prioritization
- Better tenant screening support
- Automated follow-ups
- Vacancy tracking
- Visibility into how long each unit has been available
- Clear reporting on lead source performance

Farouk specifically points out the unseen losses:

- A unit may eventually lease, but it might have leased two weeks earlier with a better process.
- A tenant may be approved, but perhaps a better-quality or longer-term tenant could have been found.
- These losses are hard to detect because they do not show up directly as line items.

2. Payments Are Fragmented

Even though Innago supports payments, not all tenants use it. Some tenants pay through other methods, including Cash App.

Farouk gives an example of a tenant sending him \$1,975 through Cash App. Because the tenant paid him personally instead of through the correct business system, Farouk had to:

1. Accept the money.
2. Transfer or replace the funds into the business account.
3. Notify his team so they understand why he deposited the money.
4. Manually record the payment in Innago.
5. Update the tenant ledger to reflect that the payment had been made.

This is a clear example of the operational problems created by tenant noncompliance and system fragmentation.

The payment process needs:

- Clear tenant payment rules.
- Stronger enforcement of approved payment methods.
- Automated payment reconciliation.
- Reduced reliance on personal payment apps.
- Centralized payment status visibility.
- Alerts for off-platform payments.
- A workflow for manually recorded exceptions.

3. Maintenance Communication Is Disorganized

Maintenance requests are partially handled through Innago, but tenants also communicate through WhatsApp, phone calls, texts, and direct messages to Farouk.

Farouk says a lot of communication happens through a WhatsApp group, especially around maintenance.

The company has:

- Two maintenance workers
- James
- Other partially involved workers or vendors who are not fully dedicated

This creates several problems:

- Requests may be scattered across different channels.

- Some issues may not be documented properly.
- Farouk may not fully trust that all maintenance issues are being escalated correctly.
- There is no clear company phone tree or routing system.
- Urgent matters may go directly to Farouk.
- Non-urgent matters may still interrupt Farouk.

Farouk wants the company to better utilize a company phone number. He describes a possible phone routing system:

- Press 1 for urgent maintenance.
- Press another number for other categories.
- Press 4 to reach the owner for urgent owner-level matters.

The key issue is that Farouk remains personally accessible because he does not fully trust the systems underneath him. He is worried that if a tenant issue is missed by staff, it may escalate into something legal, financial, or reputational before he finds out.

4. Accounting and Budget Tracking Are Not Timely Enough

Farouk does not have a frequently updated profit-and-loss report by property.

He wants updated accounting every one to two weeks, not only after the fact. His current situation makes it difficult to manage projects by budget.

For example, he mentions turning over an apartment and installing a new shower. He does not know in real time whether the project is:

- Under budget
- On budget
- Over budget
- Far over budget

He also does not know quickly enough:

- Who is responsible for an overage
- How to correct the issue
- How to learn from the project

- Whether more money should have been spent
- Whether money was overspent unnecessarily

Because budget information arrives late, the company is reactive instead of proactive.

5. Farouk Cannot Delegate Enough

A major theme is that Farouk is still involved in too many small decisions.

He says he often has to make spending decisions as small as \$100 to \$150. This prevents his team from acting like owners and keeps them acting like helpers.

He wants to delegate more authority, but he does not yet have the systems, budget controls, approval thresholds, audit trails, and reporting structures that would allow him to trust the delegation.

This limits the company's growth because Farouk's time is consumed by small operational issues instead of high-value activities.

6. The Business Is Too Reactive

Farouk describes his day as constantly reacting to "tennis balls." These include:

- Tenant messages
- Phone calls
- Maintenance requests
- Payment issues
- Staff questions
- Vendor questions
- Small spending approvals
- Leasing issues
- Accounting questions
- Insurance renewals or changes

He wants to shift his day toward asking:

"What are the one, two, or three things I need to do today that will grow my business?"

Instead, he is often putting out fires.

7. Farouk's Highest-Value Work Is Being Interrupted

Farouk says he has figured out the hardest parts of the business:

- Access to capital
- Finding deals
- Negotiating
- Growth opportunities

But these activities require focus and attention. When he is constantly pulled into daily operations, he cannot fully focus on acquisitions, deal-making, and growth.

He gives an example that he might be able to make \$20,000 in a day through higher-level work, but if he does not handle operational issues, things may start falling apart.

The website/system should therefore be designed to protect Farouk's time.

8. Insurance, Renewals, and Administrative Tracking Are Weak

Farouk mentions insurance as an example of an administrative area that needs more organization.

He wants the system to flag issues like:

- Insurance expiration dates
- Policy increases
- Unexpected premium changes
- Administrative deadlines
- Required renewals
- Document-related tasks

This suggests that the future platform should include an administrative compliance and reminders section.

Key Business Requirements

The system or website should help Farouk's business move from a founder-dependent operation to a more systemized property management company.

The solution should provide:

- A public-facing rental listings website
- A tenant application funnel
- Lead management
- Tenant screening workflow support
- Maintenance request intake
- Maintenance routing
- Centralized communication
- Tenant portal links or integrations
- Payment status visibility
- Internal task management
- Budget approval workflows
- Property-level financial reporting
- Admin document tracking
- Insurance and renewal reminders
- Owner-level dashboards
- Staff-level permissions
- Escalation rules
- Approval thresholds
- Audit trails
- Morning briefing summaries
- Reduced dependency on WhatsApp, texts, and memory

Decisions That Must Still Go Through Farouk

Farouk is open to automation and delegation, but some decisions must remain under his control, at least for the next couple of years.

These include:

- Budget definition
- Budget approval
- Legal matters
- New lease approvals
- Final approval of newly selected tenants

He says some of these approvals may only take a few minutes, but he still wants final oversight because the business is important and certain decisions are too sensitive to fully delegate right now.

Desired Daily Dashboard

Speaker 1 asks what information Farouk would want to see in one place each morning.

Farouk identifies several useful categories:

- Payments
- Open maintenance requests
- Current operational issues
- High-level overview of the day
- Possibly leasing status
- Possibly urgent tenant matters

However, Farouk clarifies that reporting alone is not enough. He does not want “another reporting” system. He wants the system to actually do things for him.

The dashboard should not just show information. It should trigger workflows, automate replies, route requests, assign tasks, and reduce manual intervention.

What the Website Should Actually Be

Based on the recording, this should be built as more than a standard brochure website.

It should be a combined:

1. Public rental website

2. Leasing funnel
3. Tenant intake system
4. Maintenance request system
5. Internal operations dashboard
6. Task and approval management tool
7. Financial visibility layer
8. Document and compliance reminder system

The first version does not need to replace every existing tool immediately. It can sit above the current tools and gradually centralize the workflow.

Recommended Website/System Structure

Public-Facing Pages

The public website should include:

- Home
- Available Rentals
- Property Detail Pages
- Apply Now
- Tenant Resources
- Maintenance Request
- Contact
- About
- FAQ

Internal Dashboard

The internal dashboard should include:

- Daily Briefing
- Leasing Pipeline

- Maintenance Requests
- Payment Exceptions
- Property Budgets
- Approval Queue
- Documents and Renewals
- Tenant Directory
- Vendor Directory
- Reports

Tenant-Facing Portal Features

The tenant-facing side should include:

- Pay rent link or payment instructions
- Maintenance request form
- Emergency maintenance instructions
- Tenant documents
- Contact preferences
- FAQ
- Move-in and move-out instructions

Staff-Facing Features

The staff side should include:

- Assigned maintenance tasks
- Tenant communication history
- Open work orders
- Spending limits
- Approval requests

- Vendor coordination notes
- Property-level task views

Owner-Facing Features

The owner/Farouk view should include:

- Daily overview
- Approval requests
- Budget exceptions
- Legal alerts
- Lease approvals
- Payment exceptions
- High-priority maintenance issues
- Vacant units
- Units at risk of delayed leasing
- Upcoming renewals
- Insurance deadlines

Methodical Build Plan

Phase 1: Discovery and Process Mapping

Before building, document the current workflows.

Map the following processes:

1. How a vacant unit becomes listed.
2. How leads currently come in from Zillow Rental and Facebook.
3. How applicants are screened.
4. How a lease is approved.
5. How tenants are onboarded.

6. How rent payments are collected.
7. How off-platform payments are handled.
8. How maintenance requests are received.
9. How maintenance work is assigned.
10. How maintenance spending is approved.
11. How completed work is documented.
12. How accounting data is collected.
13. How budgets are created and approved.
14. How insurance and admin renewals are tracked.

The goal of this phase is to identify exactly where work gets lost, delayed, duplicated, or escalated unnecessarily to Farouk.

Phase 2: Build the Public Rental Website

Start with the highest opportunity-cost area: leasing.

Build a website with a strong rental listing system.

Core features:

- Available rentals page
- Individual property pages
- Photos
- Rent amount
- Security deposit
- Bedroom/bathroom count
- Location
- Amenities
- Pet policy
- Availability date

- Application button
- Inquiry form
- Lead source tracking
- Automatic confirmation email or text

This immediately gives the business its own leasing destination instead of relying only on Zillow Rental and Facebook.

Phase 3: Build the Leasing Funnel

Once listings exist, add a structured lead and application funnel.

Features:

- Lead capture form
- Automated lead response
- Showing request form
- Pre-screening questions
- Application status tracking
- Internal notes
- Applicant comparison
- Final approval queue for Farouk

Suggested applicant stages:

1. New lead
2. Pre-screened
3. Showing requested
4. Showing completed
5. Application submitted
6. Under review
7. Recommended for approval

8. Farouk approval required

9. Approved

10. Lease sent

11. Lease signed

12. Tenant onboarded

13. Rejected or archived

Farouk should only need to step in at the final approval stage unless something unusual happens.

Phase 4: Centralize Maintenance Requests

Create a maintenance request intake form that tenants are trained to use.

Features:

- Tenant name
- Property/unit
- Phone number
- Email
- Issue category
- Urgency level
- Description
- Photos/videos
- Permission to enter
- Preferred contact method
- Emergency warning instructions

Maintenance categories could include:

- Plumbing
- Electrical

- Heating/cooling
- Appliance
- Lock/key
- Pest
- Structural
- Water leak
- Other

Urgency levels should be clearly defined:

- Emergency
- Urgent
- Standard
- Low priority

The system should automatically route requests based on category and urgency.

Phase 5: Add Phone and Message Routing

Farouk specifically wants better use of a company phone number.

Create a routing structure such as:

- Press 1 for emergency maintenance.
- Press 2 for standard maintenance.
- Press 3 for rent or payment questions.
- Press 4 for leasing.
- Press 5 for urgent owner-level matters.

The system should reduce direct calls to Farouk while preserving escalation paths for truly urgent matters.

Automated replies should tell tenants:

- Their request was received.

- What the expected response time is.
- Whether the issue qualifies as an emergency.
- What to do if there is immediate danger.
- Who will follow up.

Phase 6: Build the Daily Briefing Dashboard

Create a dashboard Farouk can check each morning.

The dashboard should show:

- New leads
- Vacant units
- Units listed but not leased
- Applications awaiting review
- Lease approvals needed
- Open maintenance requests
- Emergency maintenance issues
- Work orders overdue
- Rent payments received
- Late rent or missing payments
- Off-platform payment exceptions
- Budget approvals needed
- Properties over budget
- Insurance or document deadlines
- Legal or compliance alerts

The dashboard should focus on decisions and exceptions, not raw data.

Phase 7: Create Approval Workflows

Because Farouk cannot approve every small decision forever, the system should include approval thresholds.

Example structure:

- Staff can approve maintenance expenses under a set amount.
- Larger expenses require manager approval.
- Budget exceptions require Farouk approval.
- Legal matters always require Farouk approval.
- New leases always require Farouk approval.
- Emergency repairs can proceed immediately but must be reviewed afterward.

Each approval should include:

- Property
- Unit
- Requested amount
- Reason
- Photos or documentation
- Vendor estimate
- Budget remaining
- Recommended action
- Approval history

This allows delegation while maintaining control.

Phase 8: Add Property-Level Budget Tracking

The system should track budgets by property and ideally by project.

For each turnover or repair project, track:

- Property
- Unit

- Project type
- Approved budget
- Actual spend
- Remaining budget
- Vendor
- Responsible person
- Start date
- Completion date
- Notes
- Photos
- Over-budget explanation

This will help Farouk avoid discovering problems too late.

Phase 9: Integrate or Sync Accounting Data

Since the company is trying Short Landlord for accounting, the website/system does not need to fully replace accounting immediately.

Instead, start by building a visibility layer that can:

- Import or display accounting summaries.
- Track property-level spending.
- Show budget versus actual.
- Flag uncategorized transactions.
- Identify missing receipts.
- Show open questions from the accounting team.
- Provide a weekly or biweekly financial snapshot.

The goal is to help Farouk run the business by budget instead of reacting after money has already been spent.

Phase 10: Add Document, Insurance, and Renewal Tracking

Create an admin tracking module.

Track:

- Insurance policies
- Lease documents
- Vendor agreements
- W-9s
- Licenses
- Property documents
- Inspection dates
- Renewal deadlines
- Expiration dates
- Premium changes
- Legal notices

The system should send reminders before deadlines and flag unexpected changes, such as an insurance premium increase.

Phase 11: Tenant Adoption Plan

The system will only work if tenants actually use it.

Farouk already has this problem with Innago, so tenant adoption must be part of the build.

Adoption steps:

1. Send a formal notice explaining the approved communication and payment channels.
2. Provide simple links and instructions.
3. Add QR codes to tenant notices.
4. Place maintenance request links in email signatures and text templates.
5. Train staff to redirect tenants back to the correct system.

6. Stop accepting non-approved payment methods except under documented exceptions.
7. Provide reminders before rent due dates.
8. Make the maintenance form faster than texting Farouk.
9. Track tenants who repeatedly bypass the system.
10. Follow up with those tenants individually.

Phase 12: Reduce WhatsApp Dependency

WhatsApp may still be useful internally, but it should not be the official system of record.

The website/system should become the source of truth for:

- Maintenance requests
- Tenant issues
- Task assignments
- Approvals
- Payment exceptions
- Vendor updates
- Project notes

If WhatsApp is still used, important information should be copied or automatically pushed into the system.

Phase 13: Escalation Rules

Define exactly when Farouk should be contacted.

Farouk should receive alerts for:

- Legal threats
- Serious tenant complaints
- Emergency maintenance unresolved after a set time
- New lease approvals
- Budget approvals above threshold

- Major spending exceptions
- Insurance expiration risks
- Payment issues above a certain amount
- Safety issues
- Any issue that has gone overdue

Farouk should not receive alerts for:

- Routine maintenance intake
- Basic scheduling
- Small approved expenses
- Standard tenant questions
- Normal payment confirmations
- Non-urgent status updates

Phase 14: Staff Accountability and Cross-Auditing

Farouk mentioned the need for cross-auditing so that no single person has unchecked control.

The system should include:

- User roles
- Permission levels
- Activity logs
- Approval history
- Task ownership
- Completion evidence
- Receipt upload requirements
- Budget variance tracking
- Internal review steps

This helps Farouk delegate without losing control.

Suggested Minimum Viable Product

The first build should avoid trying to solve everything at once.

A strong MVP should include:

1. Public rental listings page
2. Property detail pages
3. Lead capture form
4. Rental application/pre-screening workflow
5. Maintenance request form
6. Internal maintenance dashboard
7. Daily owner briefing
8. Approval queue
9. Basic property budget tracking
10. Document and insurance reminder tracker

This would immediately address the biggest problems:

- Leasing inefficiency
- Scattered maintenance requests
- Founder bottleneck
- Lack of daily overview
- Poor delegation structure
- Missed admin deadlines

Recommended Data Structure

Properties

Each property record should include:

- Property name
- Address
- Units
- Ownership/entity
- Insurance policy
- Documents
- Active tenants
- Vacancy status
- Budget
- Maintenance history
- Financial summary

Units

Each unit record should include:

- Unit number
- Status
- Rent amount
- Deposit
- Bedrooms
- Bathrooms
- Availability date
- Current tenant
- Listing status
- Turnover budget
- Maintenance history

Tenants

Each tenant record should include:

- Name
- Contact information
- Unit
- Lease start date
- Lease end date
- Payment status
- Communication preferences
- Maintenance history
- Notes
- Portal adoption status

Leads and Applicants

Each lead/applicant record should include:

- Name
- Contact information
- Source
- Desired unit
- Pre-screening answers
- Showing status
- Application status
- Screening notes
- Approval status
- Farouk approval timestamp

Maintenance Requests

Each maintenance request should include:

- Tenant
- Property
- Unit
- Category
- Urgency
- Description
- Photos/videos
- Assigned person
- Status
- Cost estimate
- Approved budget
- Actual cost
- Completion notes
- Completion photos

Approvals

Each approval record should include:

- Request type
- Requested by
- Property/unit
- Amount
- Reason
- Supporting documents

- Approval status
- Approved by
- Date approved
- Notes

Documents and Renewals

Each document record should include:

- Document type
- Related property/vendor/tenant
- Expiration date
- Renewal date
- Responsible person
- Reminder schedule
- Current status

Priority Features by Business Impact

Highest Priority

- Leasing website and lead funnel
- Maintenance request centralization
- Daily briefing dashboard
- Approval queue
- Payment exception tracking

Medium Priority

- Property-level budget tracking
- Document and insurance reminders
- Staff task management

- Vendor directory
- Tenant adoption tracking

Later Priority

- Deep accounting integrations
- Advanced analytics
- Automated tenant scoring
- AI-based communication summaries
- Fully integrated phone system
- Custom mobile app

Summary for Building the Website Methodically

Farouk's business manages about 100 tenants and currently relies on several disconnected tools, including Innago, Zillow Rental, Facebook, WhatsApp, and a new accounting service called Short Landlord. Innago is mainly used for tenant payments, ledgers, maintenance requests, communication, and documents, but tenant adoption is inconsistent. Zillow Rental and Facebook are used for leasing because the business does not yet have its own rental listings website.

The biggest operational problems are fragmented leasing, scattered tenant communication, inconsistent payment behavior, weak real-time accounting visibility, lack of property-level budget tracking, and overdependence on Farouk for small decisions. Farouk is constantly reacting to issues instead of focusing on growth activities like finding deals, negotiating, and deploying capital.

The website should be built as an operational platform, not just a marketing site. It should include a public-facing rental website, a leasing funnel, maintenance request intake, communication routing, daily dashboards, budget approval workflows, document reminders, and staff accountability tools.

The first priority should be to build a rental listings website with lead capture and application workflows. This addresses the largest opportunity cost: leasing delays and tenant quality. Next, build a maintenance request system that routes tenant issues away from Farouk and into a structured dashboard. Then add a daily briefing dashboard so Farouk can see urgent issues, open maintenance, late payments, leasing status, approvals, and admin deadlines in one place.

After that, add approval workflows so Farouk can delegate small decisions while keeping control over major spending, legal issues, budget approvals, and new lease approvals. Property-level budget tracking should be added so the team can see whether turnovers and repairs are under

or over budget before it is too late. Finally, add document tracking for insurance, leases, renewals, vendor agreements, and other administrative deadlines.

The MVP should include:

1. Public rental listings
2. Property detail pages
3. Lead capture
4. Applicant/pre-screening workflow
5. Maintenance request form
6. Internal maintenance dashboard
7. Daily owner briefing
8. Approval queue
9. Basic property budget tracking
10. Insurance and document reminders

The long-term goal is to reduce Farouk's direct involvement in daily fires and create a system where staff can operate with clear authority, clear budgets, clear task ownership, and clear escalation rules. Farouk should only be involved when his judgment is truly needed: budget approval, legal matters, new lease approvals, major exceptions, and growth decisions.